```
#change -d 0 sam
```

…assuming that 'sam' is the user name.

The *change* command changes the number of days between password changes and the date of the last password change. This information is used by the system to determine when a user must change his/her password. Setting it to 0 forces the user to change the password on the next log in.

– Suresh Jagtap, smjagtap@gmail.com

Reviewing your boot log

Linux builds several log files to track the progress of the various activities it executes. One such log is created and displayed when you boot the system. This log lists the results of various services and processes that are completed at boot time. This is usually a very long list. Unfortunately, this display disappears as soon as the booting is over. Sometimes you may like to review this log file for troubleshooting purposes, when the system is up and running.

To review the long list of events displayed at boot time, use the following command:

```
more /var/log/boot.log
```

You can also monitor a log until a process dies, as follows:

```
tail -F --pid=1234 <filename>
```

You can get the process ID (pid) using the command below:

```
ps -ef | grep <processname>
```

You can build the above command into a more elaborate shell script, to mail the output and remotely analyse the messages sent out by any process.

– Dr S. Parthasarathy, drpartha@gmail.com

Create a talking clock from the terminal

Command line junkies know the power of the terminal. We can do many complex tasks efficiently with just a few commands. So let us create a talking clock from the terminal.

First, install the 'espeak' speech synthesiser. On Ubuntu systems, use the 'apt' package manager as follows:

```
[bash]$ sudo apt-get install espeak
```

Now, you can display the current time using the 'date' command as follows:

```
[bash]$ echo $(date +%-I) $(date +%-M) $(date +%p)
8 42 PM
```

In the above example, the '%I' format specifier displays hours ranging from 1 to 12. The '%M' format displays minutes ranging from 0 to 59. The '%p' format specifier displays the locale's equivalent of either AM or PM. By default, the 'date' command does the padding of output fields. The hyphen (-) sign before the '%I' and '%M' format specifier restricts padding of the output fields.

To create the talking clock, just pass the output of the above 'date' command to the 'espeak' utility, as follows:

```
[bash]$ echo $(date +%-I) $(date +%-M) $(date +%p) |
espeak
```

Isn't this interesting? For demonstration purposes, I used only hours and minutes. Going further, you can use days of the week, months, years and so on.

– Narendra Kangralkar, narendrakangralkar@gmail.com

Special character printing in Vim

Some characters are not on the keyboard—for example, the copyright character (©). To type these letters in Vim, you can use digraphs, where two characters represent one. To enter a © symbol, for example, type CTRL-Kc0.

To find out what digraphs are available, use the following command:

```
:digraphs
```

The Vim editor will display the digraph-mapping table.

For example, the digraph you get by typing CTRL-K~! is the character (¡).This is character number 161.

– Daga Saurabh, daga.saurabh@ymail.com

END

Share Your Linux Recipes!

The joy of using Linux is in finding ways to get around problems—take them head on, defeat them! We invite you to share your tips and tricks with us for publication in *OSFY* so that they can reach a wider audience. Your tips could be related to administration, programming, troubleshooting or general tweaking. Submit them at *www.opensourceforu.com*. The sender of each published tip will get a T-shirt.